

Nasir Almasri

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Research Interests

comparative politics; security studies; authoritarian institutions and democratic backsliding; political violence; courts and counterterrorism; colonial legacies; opposition movements; Middle East and North Africa.

Appointments

Wellesley College Mellon Fellow, Peace & Justice Studies	Wellesley, MA 2026 – Present
Boston University Postdoctoral Scholar, Society of Fellows	Boston, MA 2024 – 2026
Harvard Kennedy School Predoctoral Scholar, Middle East Initiative	Cambridge, MA 2022 – 2024
Middle East Institute Graduate Fellow	Washington, DC 2023 – 2024

Education

MIT PhD in Political Science	2017 – 2024
The University of Chicago MA in International Relations <i>Morton A. Kaplan Prize for Best MA Thesis</i>	2015 – 2017
Southern Illinois University Edwardsville BS in Political Science (<i>Summa Cum Laude</i>) BA in History (<i>Summa Cum Laude</i>)	2011 – 2015

Publications

Book Project

1. *The Colonial Origins of Opposition: State Formation, Political Competition, and the Evolution of Radicalism*

Refereed Articles

1. 2026. “Colonial Legacies and the Dynamics of Opposition: How Factional Power Shapes Cycles of Moderation and Radicalization” *Perspectives on Politics*: pp. 1-23. [Link](#) 
2. 2025. “Moral Shocks and (De)mobilization: The Case of the Palestinian Liberation Movement.” *Contention*, Volume 13, Issue 1, pp. 102-137 (with Dana El Kurd and Alexei Abrahams). [Link](#) 
3. 2022. “Mental Health and the PhD: Insights and Implications for Political Science.” *PS: Politics and Political Science*, Volume 55, Issue 2, pp. 347-353 (with Blair Read and Clara Vandeweerd). [Link](#) 

Working Papers

1. “Before the War on Terror: The History of Security Institutions and Counterterrorism Adaptation after 9/11”
2. “Where is the Madani State? The Evolution of Political Parties in the Middle East” (with Marsin Alshamary)
3. “Mobilization without Organization” (with Dana El Kurd and Alexei Abrahams)
4. “Islam, the War on Terror, and Pitfalls of the Moderate-Radical Dichotomy”

Work in Progress

1. “Courts under Pressure: Authoritarianism and Terrorism Prosecution”

Book Chapters

1. 2026. “When work is personal: closeness to research and its effect on well-being,” with Amirah Aly, in *Academic Chutes and Ladders* (Bloomsbury), ed. by Kerry Crawford and Leah Windsor. [Link](#) 
2. 2022. “Mental health and well-being in graduate school,” with Dana El Kurd, in *Strategies for Navigating Grad School*, edited by by Kevin G. Lorentz II et al (American Political Science Association). [Link](#) 

Teaching

“People Power in the Digital Age,” Wellesley College	Fall 2026
“Introduction to Comparative Politics,” Boston University	Summer 2026
“People Power in Global Politics,” Boston University	Spring 2025, 2026
“Introduction to International Politics,” Boston University	Summer 2025, 2026
Teaching Assistant, “Causes of War and Peace,” MIT	Spring 2020
Teaching Assistant, “Introduction to Comparative Politics,” MIT	Fall 2019
<i>Additional Training:</i> Teaching + Learning Lab, MIT	
Teaching Development Fellow, Dept. of Political Science	2023-2024
Kaufman Teaching Certificate Program	Spring 2023

Research Consulting

North American Arab Council for the Social Sciences	Remote
Senior Consultant Survey Design and Analysis	2026 – Present
Program on Political Violence	Chicago, IL
Research Associate	2016 - 2017
Chicago Program on Security and Threats	Chicago, IL
Research Associate	2016 - 2017

Editorial Service

Journal of Global South Studies	Remote
Member, Board of Editors	2026 – Present

Grants and Awards

Institute for Humane Studies at George Mason University, \$2500 (2025)
Islamic Scholarship Fund, Makhraj Endowed Scholarship, \$4000 (2023)
Center for International Studies, Summer Study Fellowship, \$3500 (2021, 2022)
Islamic Scholarship Fund, Alassar Endowed Scholarship, \$5000 (2022)
Security Studies Program Special Summer Funding, \$3000 (2020)
Kenan Sahin Presidential Graduate Fellowship, MIT (2017-18)
Islamic Scholarship Fund, \$3000 (2017)
Morton A. Kaplan Prize for Best MA Thesis, \$1000, University of Chicago (2017)
University Full Tuition Scholarship, University of Chicago (2016-17)
Social Science Full Tuition Scholarship, University of Chicago (2015-16)
Dr. Gordon D. Bush Political Science Award, \$1000, SIUE (2014-15)
Dr. Timothy P. Fischer Award in Historical Studies, \$500, SIUE (2013-15)
URCA Associate Research Grant, \$2400, SIUE (2014-15)
Outstanding Student Leader Award, SIUE (2013, 2014, 2015)
Chancellor's Meridian Full Tuition Scholarship, SIUE (2011-15)

Talks and Presentations

Guest Lecture: The History of the Muslim Brotherhood	Oct. 2025
Boston College, Course: Religion-State Relations in the Middle East	Oct. 2024
 Guest Lecture: Foreign Intervention in the Middle East	 March 2025
Harvard Kennedy School	
 Guest Lecture: War and Peace in the Middle East	
Harvard Kennedy School	Nov. 2024
The Fletcher School at Tufts University	Nov. 2024
Massachusetts Institute of Technology	Oct. 2024
 Invited Talk: The Rise and Fall of Revolution in the Middle East	 Oct. 2024
Bowling Green State University, Engelhart Speaker Series	
 Panel: Surveillance in the Muslim Community, Islamic History Month	 Nov. 2020
Simon Fraser University, Centre for Comparative Muslim Studies	

Conferences and Workshops

American Political Science Association (2025)
NDPS Conference, Brown University (2024)
Arab Center for Research and Policy Studies, Doha, Qatar (2024)
Middle East Research Workshop, Harvard University (2024)
Middle East Studies Association (2023)
Southwest Mixed-Methods Research (2023)
American Political Science Association (2023; canceled due to labor strike)
Middle East Research Workshop, Harvard University (2023)
Midwest Political Science Association (2023)
Middle East Research Workshop, Harvard University (2022)
Midwest Political Science Association (2021)
Middle East Research Workshop, Harvard University (2021)
POMEPS Junior Scholars Workshop (2020)
Middle East Research Workshop, Harvard University (2020)
MIT Security Studies Working Group (2020)
Midwest Political Science Association (2017)
International Studies Association (2017)
University of Chicago Program on International Security Policy (2017)

Leadership and Service

Massachusetts Institute of Technology

Teaching Development Fellow, Political Science (2023-2024)
Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Working Group in Political Science (2020-2021)
Graduate Anti-Racist Political Science Collective (2020-2022)
Coordinator, Security Studies Working Group (2019-2020)
Chair, Graduate Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Committee (2018-2019)
Executive Member, MIT Graduate Student Council (2018-2019)

The University of Chicago

Social Science Graduate Student Advisory Council (2015-2016)

Southern Illinois University Edwardsville

Chair, Multicultural Center Council (2014-2015)
University Policy and Budget Council (2011-2012, 2014-2015)
University Quality Council (2014-2015)
Search Committee, Dean of College of Arts and Sciences (2014-2015)

Language

English (native), Arabic (heritage), Spanish (intermediate)

References

Richard Nielsen: ✉ rnielsen@mit.edu
Roger Petersen: ✉ rpeters@mit.edu
Taylor Boas: ✉ tboas@bu.edu
Jeremy Menchik: ✉ menchik@bu.edu